after the Emergency, when Indira Gandhi contested a by-election from Karnataka's Chikmagalur in 1978, Patil, who now headed the Janata Party's Karnataka unit, was chosen to stand against her.[24] Indira won easily, giving birth to the famous poll slogan 'Ek Sherni Sau Langur, Chikmagalur Bhai Chikmagalur' (One tigress, 100 langurs, Chikmagalur brother Chikmagalur).

In 1980, when the BJP was formed, some Lingayat leaders remained with the Janata Party, others had returned to the Congress. Patil was among the latter. Despite their Chikmagalur battle, Indira Gandhi appointed him a cabinet minister in 1980.[25] In the decade that followed, the Congress tried to woo Lingayat voters. As part of this outreach, when it came back to power in Karnataka in 1989, Patil was appointed chief minister again—the first time such apex leadership was given to a Congress Lingayat leader in two decades, thus signalling a shift in Congress strategy. His subsequent unceremonious removal from power in 1990 by Rajiv Gandhi, similarly, came to signify an important turning point in Karnataka politics. It was seen by many in the community as an insult to Lingayat pride and heralded the first breach by the BJP into the community's vote. A year later, in the parliamentary elections, it won the party its very first victories in Karnataka.[26]

This is how Patil's public sacking came to be. In October 1990, communal riots broke out in some parts of Karnataka. Patil, who had just suffered a minor stroke, was convalescing at home. Congress leader Rajiv Gandhi, having recently lost the 1989 elections, decided to cut short the Sadbhavana Yatra he had embarked upon in north India and make a sudden, 'unexpected' visit to Bangalore to take stock. After a helicopter ride to the riot-hit Channapatna town on 7 October, he met Patil at his home and drove back to Bangalore airport to board a chartered aircraft. Several ministers and hundreds of party workers had gathered to see him off. As they waited outside the VIP lounge, Gandhi met with waiting reporters. One of them asked him when the state government would start functioning properly again. Gandhi replied, 'In four days.' Before the startling announcement could be fully digested, he added that the Congress Legislature Party would meet in a couple of days to 'elect a new leader' and that Patil 'was not really well' and had 'agreed to step